

“I don’t think they mind.”

He looked at her then, really looked at her. The manic energy drained out of him, leaving something brittle in its place.

“Do you know what it’s like,” he said, “to spend six months pretending to be someone else, and then when you stop, you aren’t sure if you exist when no one is watching?”

The silence stretched. Outside, the flashes stopped. The paparazzi were moving on.

Elara closed her ledger. She picked up a pen and began to trace the grain of the wood on the counter.

“I had a cat,” she said. “A ginger tom. He died three years ago. Sometimes I still step over the place where he used to sleep on the rug.”

He didn’t move. He didn’t say anything. He just watched her trace the wood grain.

“Did you get another cat?”

“No.”

He nodded, slowly. He walked to the counter and set the book down. “I’ll take the poetry.”

“That’s £4.50.”

He pulled a damp ten-pound note from his pocket and laid it on the wood. “Keep the change.”

“We don’t do tips.” She slid the change across the counter.

He didn’t take it immediately. His hand hovered over the coins, close to hers. The air in the shop felt suddenly thin. Then he scooped the money up, put the book in his pocket, and walked out into the rain.

Elara watched him go. She picked up her pen and opened the ledger. She wrote the sale in the wrong column, putting the £4.50 under expenses instead of income.

She sat with the mistake for a moment before she fixed it.